unmade in the exercise. As the event got closer, the tension became palpable.

Around the end of May 1982, 9 Maratha LI, 3 Garhwal Rifles with their attached troops, and other arms and services participating in the exercise gathered at their respective rendezvous, and readied themselves for the exercise. It had taken the units from a week to ten days to reach their exercise locations as they had to march on foot beyond the point where the road ended in those days. 9 Maratha LI had to do the longest trek, as we had to establish our firm base the farthest, and then commence the offensive into Blueland. It required a colossal effort to move everything required for the exercise on foot. There was a large requirement of porters to carry the head loads. We also organized a system of 'fighting porters' from the available manpower; they comprised soldiers meant for logistical, clerical and other non-combat roles during peace time. However, during combat in such terrain, every man mattered and had to be mustered.

Even though it was summer, the monsoon was not far away. In those days, there were no satellites to give us weather data. The controlling HQ of the exercise was established by the division near the roadhead to enable the control HQ to decide the outcome of the battles that would be fought, in real time. A fairly elaborate camp was set up there to accommodate the high-profile visitors and observers from all over the Eastern Command. Never before was an exercise of a brigade with two battalions, in such a remote area, witnessed by such a galaxy of brass. In addition to our GOC, Major General Mayadas, there were the corps commander, Lieutenant General Ranjit Singh Dyal, MVC, and the GOC-in-C, Lieutenant General A.S. Vaidya, MVC and bar, and a host of other two-star and one-star ranking officers to give them company.

Before the manoeuvres commenced, the commanders of Redland and Blueland were directed to present their plans. My battalion was representing a brigade of the Redland forces, and I was tasked to launch an offensive to advance and capture territory up to a given point. Contesting my offensive was an infantry battalion group of the Blueland.